GLYCEROL SUPPOSITORY

Works in 15–30 min

Safe in infants & pregnancy

CHEMICAL NAME Propane-1,2,3-triol (glycerin) moulded with gelatin
CLASS Rectal osmotic/irritant laxative
TRADE NAMES Glycerin suppositories (adult 4 g, child 2 g, infant 1 g) · Fleet Glycerin

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Acute constipation needing rapid relief.
- Rectal loading of hard stool.
- Infant constipation (occasional).
- Bowel care programmes (spinal injury).

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- Hyperosmotic and mild irritant effect on rectal mucosa → draws water into rectum, stimulates rectal contraction and defaecation reflex.

ADMINISTRATION

- **PR:** moisten with water; insert pointed end first beyond anal sphincter, patient lying on left side with knees bent.
- Retain for 15–20 min.
- Must contact rectal wall (not inserted into faeces).

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Rectal discomfort, burning.
- Abdominal cramping.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- Rectal irritation with frequent use.

DOSAGES

- **Adult:** 4 g suppository once as needed.
- **Children 1–12 yr:** 2 g.
- **Infants <1 yr:** 1 g.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Intestinal obstruction; acute abdomen.
- Rectal bleeding of unknown cause.
- **Caution:** recent rectal surgery, neutropenia.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- None significant.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Onset:** 15–30 min.
- Acts locally; minimal absorption.

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Explain procedure, ensure privacy.
- Use gloved, lubricated finger; insert beside stool against rectal wall.
- Ensure toilet/commode access; record result.
- Avoid in neutropenic patients (infection risk).

PATIENT EDUCATION

- Lie on your left side; hold in for 15–20 minutes.
- Do not use regularly without advice.
- Increase fibre and fluids.

KEY POINTS

- Rectal laxative — works in 15–30 min.
- Insert against rectal wall.
- Adult 4 g, child 2 g, infant 1 g.
- Safe in pregnancy and infants.

SOURCES CHECKED **[560]** Glycerol 1g Suppositories (UK SmPC) **[561]** Glycerol 2g Suppositories (UK SmPC) **[562]** Glycerol 4g Suppositories (UK SmPC)

Full references p. 432–457